

TEACHING STATEMENT

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My goal as a teacher is to empower students to see economics not as a collection of abstract theories, but as a powerful toolkit for understanding the world around them. I find immense satisfaction in witnessing the moment a student connects a model to a real-life scenario, suddenly able to understand a complex policy debate or predict behavior. My teaching philosophy is centered on four core principles: (1) connecting theory to real-world application, (2) developing analytical skills through active learning, (3) tailoring my methods to engage students with advanced material, and (4) fostering a supportive, mentoring-focused environment. My commitment to this approach has been demonstrated through my experience as a lecturer at the Universidad de Santiago and as a Teaching Assistant at the University of Illinois. This dedication has been formally recognized by my inclusion on the University of Illinois' "List of Teachers Ranked as Excellent by Their Students," a distinction driven by evaluation scores where students rated my effectiveness at an average of 4.85 out of 5.0, complementing my record in Chile where students rated me at 6.4 out of 7.0.

Connecting Theory to Real-World Application. To build the bridge from theory to application, I ground economic concepts in students' own context, finding that tangible, local examples are the most effective way to connect with a diverse classroom. For instance, in my Microeconomic Principles course of over 40 students in Chile, I moved beyond textbook examples to explain comparative advantage by analyzing the country's role as a global copper exporter. To illustrate externalities, I used the construction of new Metro lines in Santiago to show how public projects create local spillovers. I apply this same principle as a Teaching Assistant for Microeconomic Principles in the U.S., using the creation of public parks over old subway tracks in Chicago to show that these economic forces are everywhere. Beyond these large-scale cases, I reinforce every topic with a clear, step-by-step thinking process. For example, when teaching consumer theory, I consistently model the same two-part procedure for any problem: first, we translate the wording into a precise economic question, and second, we outline the exact steps needed to reach the solution. This methodical approach prepares students for evaluations and is a practice they have found particularly helpful, with one student commenting, "Cristhian does a great job of explaining concepts and providing examples to help explain." My goal is to empower students to see these forces at play in their own lives and use economic reasoning to critically evaluate public policy.

Developing Intuition Through Active Learning. To truly internalize concepts like market equilibrium, students need to experience them. At the Universidad de Santiago, I designed an in-class simulation where students became part of a competitive market, while a large bag of candy represented total profits. Positive profits attracted new "firms," shrinking the share for incumbents, while the prospect of negative profits pushed "firms" to exit. This enables students to intuitively understand how markets tend toward a zero-profit equilibrium. I apply this same hands-on philosophy to my TA discussion sections, transforming them into collaborative problem-solving sessions. While working through a problem, I constantly ask open-ended questions to encourage participation. I make a point not only to call on enthusiastic students but also to engage with those who participate less. If a student is unsure of the answer, I first ask for their intuition. If they are on the right track, I encourage them to elaborate on the next step; if not, I invite another student to build on their idea or suggest an alternative. This process creates a low-stakes, collaborative environment where students learn from the material and each other. It's an approach students have described as "immensely helpful in understanding the course," as it builds a strong foundation of economic intuition that gives meaning to formal quantitative training.

Engaging Students with Advanced Material. While teaching more advanced courses, my focus shifts to fostering their enthusiasm for the technical aspects of the discipline. I show students that a deeper

technical knowledge allows them to go beyond simply applying a theory and instead lets them see what it doesn't explain. For example, when teaching monopoly, we discuss how testing for monopolistic behavior is an active research frontier that requires more complex models than the simple equations in their textbook. This helps them see theory not as a static set of rules, but as an evolving research field.

At the same time, I work to build their confidence with these technical tools. Students in Intermediate Micro, for instance, quickly learn to solve complex problems using economic intuition, such as setting the MRS equal to the price ratio. Later in the semester, and drawing from my Engineering background, I introduce the full Lagrangian method, not as a new, intimidating topic, but to show them the formal mathematics behind the intuitive approach they have already mastered. By drawing these parallels, they realize they can handle complex math without fear. It is this approach that I believe makes rigorous material engaging, and my students seem to agree, with one commenting, "His excitement to teach the material made it very easy to learn." My goal is to create an inclusive and energetic classroom where students feel confident tackling complex theories, knowing that I will make sure everyone is included.

Fostering a Supportive, Mentoring-Focused Environment. A student's confidence is critical, and I see mentoring as a key part of my role. Drawing on my background in team sports, I work to create an environment where students feel comfortable pushing past challenges. This starts with thorough preparation, an effort my students notice. As one commented, their TA "prepares... quite a lot (his iPad notes) beforehand," which allows me to address any questions that arise. I make a point to identify students who are struggling and personally encourage them to visit my office hours. While only a few students would attend at first, by the end of each semester, my office was consistently full. The goal is to foster an environment where students feel confident seeking help, a point reflected in one student's comment that I was "easy to approach for any questions that [they] may have had." By demonstrating this dedication, I aim not only to help students master the material but also to build their confidence as future economists.

Ultimately, I view teaching as a crucial factor in improving public policy by enhancing the public's understanding of its scope and limitations. By empowering students with a strong analytical foundation and fostering their intrinsic motivation to learn, I hope to help them not only to better critique the policies that affect them but also to contribute to finding innovative solutions. This commitment to developing the next generation of critical thinkers and problem-solvers is at the heart of my identity as both a researcher and an educator.